# Industrials Competitive Intelligence Report

## Who's Buying What — and Why It Matters

*Q1 2026: Industrial Engagement Map*

Q1 2026 — Mapping Industrial Startup Engagement

**60 Industrial Companies | 325 Total Engagements | 148 Unique Startups**

**602 Startups Tracked | 9 Categories | 100+ Alias Mappings**

**ThreadMoat Research**

Michael Finocchiaro

*March 2026*

Proprietary data pipeline — ThreadMoat enriched database

200+ founder interviews including *AI Across the Product Lifecycle* podcast

© 2026 ThreadMoat Research / Michael Finocchiaro. All rights reserved.

For licensing inquiries, contact michael@threadmoat.com

# Contents

**Industrials Competitive Intelligence Report** **2**
Executive Summary . . . 2
Methodology . . . 3
Relationship Extraction . . . 3
Engagement Counting . . . 3
Limitations . . . 3
Top 20 Industrial Companies by Startup Engagement . . . 3
Company Profiles: Top 10 . . . 4
Category Concentration Analysis . . . 7
Most-Targeted Categories . . . 7
Concentrators vs. Diversifiers . . . 8
Competitive Intelligence Matrix . . . 10
Highest-Overlap Pairs . . . 10
Technology Clusters . . . 10
Reading the Matrix . . . 13
Implications for Technology Buyers . . . 13
Dual-Role Lock-In Signals . . . 13
Category Signals for Procurement . . . 13
Competitive Positioning Reads . . . 14
What to Watch . . . 14

# Industrials Competitive Intelligence Report

*2026-Q1 — ThreadMoat Engineering Software Database*

---

## Executive Summary

This report maps the engagement patterns of 60 major industrial companies across a database of 602 engineering software startups. These 60 companies account for 325 total engagements — 251 as customers and 74 as investors or venture backers.

The three most active industrials are Siemens (24 engagements), NVIDIA (19 engagements), BMW (19 engagements). Customer relationships outnumber investment relationships by 3.4:1, indicating that large industrials are far more likely to buy from startups than to invest in them. This ratio varies significantly by company: NVIDIA and Samsung engage primarily through their venture arms, while Volkswagen and Ford operate as pure customers with zero recorded investments.

The categories attracting the most industrial attention are Factory Futures (MES, Design Intelligence (CAD), Extreme Analysis (CAE. Factory Futures (MES/IIoT) dominates because manufacturing execution touches every industrial operation, from assembly lines to supply chain visibility. Simulation and analysis tools rank second, driven by aerospace and automotive demand for physics-based digital twins. Design intelligence (CAD) places third — the starting point of every product development cycle.

10 of the top 20 industrials maintain dual roles — acting as both customer and investor for at least one startup. These dual relationships signal strategic lock-in: a company that both uses and funds a startup has a deeper dependency than a standard vendor contract implies. Siemens, NVIDIA, BMW, and Schneider Electric all exhibit this pattern.

The overlap analysis reveals three distinct clusters: an automotive cluster (BMW, Volkswagen, Ford) sharing factory and design startups, an aerospace cluster (Airbus, GE, Boeing) converging on simulation tools, and a technology platform cluster (NVIDIA, Microsoft) competing to own the compute layer for engineering software. These clusters define the competitive fault lines in industrial technology procurement.

# Methodology

The data source is the ThreadMoat database of 602 engineering software startups, covering categories from CAD and simulation to manufacturing execution and supply chain management. Each startup record includes structured fields for company name, primary category, known customers, and investors or venture capital backers.

### Relationship Extraction

Relationships are extracted from two fields per startup: Known Customers and Investors/VCs. Each field is parsed to identify individual company names. An alias resolution layer maps corporate venture arms, subsidiaries, and brand variants to canonical parent companies — for example, Next47 maps to Siemens, BMW i Ventures maps to BMW, and NVentures maps to NVIDIA. SE Ventures resolves to Schneider Electric, M12 resolves to Microsoft, and Intel Capital resolves to Intel.

The alias map uses exact case-insensitive matching with 100+ entries covering 60 industrial companies. No substring or fuzzy matching is applied, which prevents false positives (e.g., 'GE' does not match 'General Catalyst' or 'Genesis'). Each engagement is classified as either 'customer' (the industrial buys from the startup) or 'investor' (the industrial has backed the startup financially).

### Engagement Counting

A company's total engagement count is the number of unique startups it appears in, counted separately for customer and investor roles. If Siemens is listed as a customer of Startup A and an investor in Startup B, that counts as 2 engagements. If Siemens is both customer and investor of Startup C, that counts as 2 engagements (one per role). This approach captures the full scope of a company's startup exposure.

### Limitations

244 of 602 startups (41%) have undisclosed or missing customer data. The actual industrial engagement numbers are therefore a lower bound. Companies with strong NDA practices — common in defense and energy — are likely underrepresented. Additionally, the database captures publicly known relationships; private pilot programs and undisclosed evaluation agreements are not included.

# Top 20 Industrial Companies by Startup Engagement

The table below ranks the 20 most active industrial companies by total startup engagements. The Customer column counts startups where the industrial is a known buyer. The Investor column counts startups where the industrial (or its venture arm) has provided funding. Top Category is the category with the most engagements for that company.

| Rank | Company | Customer | Investor | Total | Top Category |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Siemens | 20 | 4 | 24 | Factory Futures (MES |
| 2 | NVIDIA | 5 | 14 | 19 | Extreme Analysis (CAE |
| 3 | BMW | 14 | 5 | 19 | Factory Futures (MES |
| 4 | Airbus | 11 | 1 | 12 | Extreme Analysis (CAE |
| 5 | Bosch | 11 | 1 | 12 | Factory Futures (MES |
| 6 | Volkswagen | 9 | 0 | 9 | Factory Futures (MES |
| 7 | Ford | 9 | 0 | 9 | Factory Futures (MES |
| 8 | Intel | 5 | 4 | 9 | Design Intelligence (CAD) |
| 9 | Microsoft | 5 | 4 | 9 | Extreme Analysis (CAE |
| 10 | Schneider Electric | 5 | 4 | 9 | Factory Futures (MES |
| 11 | General Electric | 7 | 1 | 8 | Extreme Analysis (CAE |
| 12 | Samsung | 3 | 5 | 8 | Extreme Analysis (CAE |
| 13 | Lockheed Martin | 5 | 2 | 7 | Design Intelligence (CAD) |
| 14 | Autodesk | 2 | 5 | 7 | Adaptive Manufacturing (AM |
| 15 | HP | 6 | 1 | 7 | Design Intelligence (CAD) |
| 16 | NASA | 6 | 1 | 7 | Design Intelligence (CAD) |
| 17 | Honda | 6 | 1 | 7 | Extreme Analysis (CAE |
| 18 | Toyota | 5 | 2 | 7 | Design Intelligence (CAD) |
| 19 | Schaeffler | 6 | 1 | 7 | Cognitive Thread (PLM |
| 20 | Safran | 6 | 0 | 6 | Design Intelligence (CAD) |

## Company Profiles: Top 10

The following profiles summarize each company's engagement pattern, category concentration, and strategic posture. Customer-heavy profiles indicate operational procurement; investor-heavy profiles indicate platform or portfolio strategy.

**Siemens** (24 engagements — 20 customer, 4 investor). Siemens engages primarily as a customer, spread across 7 categories. The top category is Factory Futures (MES, accounting for 46% of engagements. Siemens holds dual roles (customer and investor) with PhysicsX, rhobot.ai. Siemens is the most active industrial across the dataset, with the broadest category spread and the highest customer count.

**NVIDIA** (19 engagements — 5 customer, 14 investor). NVIDIA engages primarily as an investor, spread across 8 categories. The top category is Extreme Analysis (CAE, accounting for 21% of engagements. NVIDIA holds dual roles (customer and investor) with Phaidra, PhysicsX. NVIDIA is the only top-5 industrial that engages primarily through investment rather than procurement, reflecting its platform strategy of funding startups that build on its GPU compute stack.

**BMW** (19 engagements — 14 customer, 5 investor). BMW engages mostly as a customer

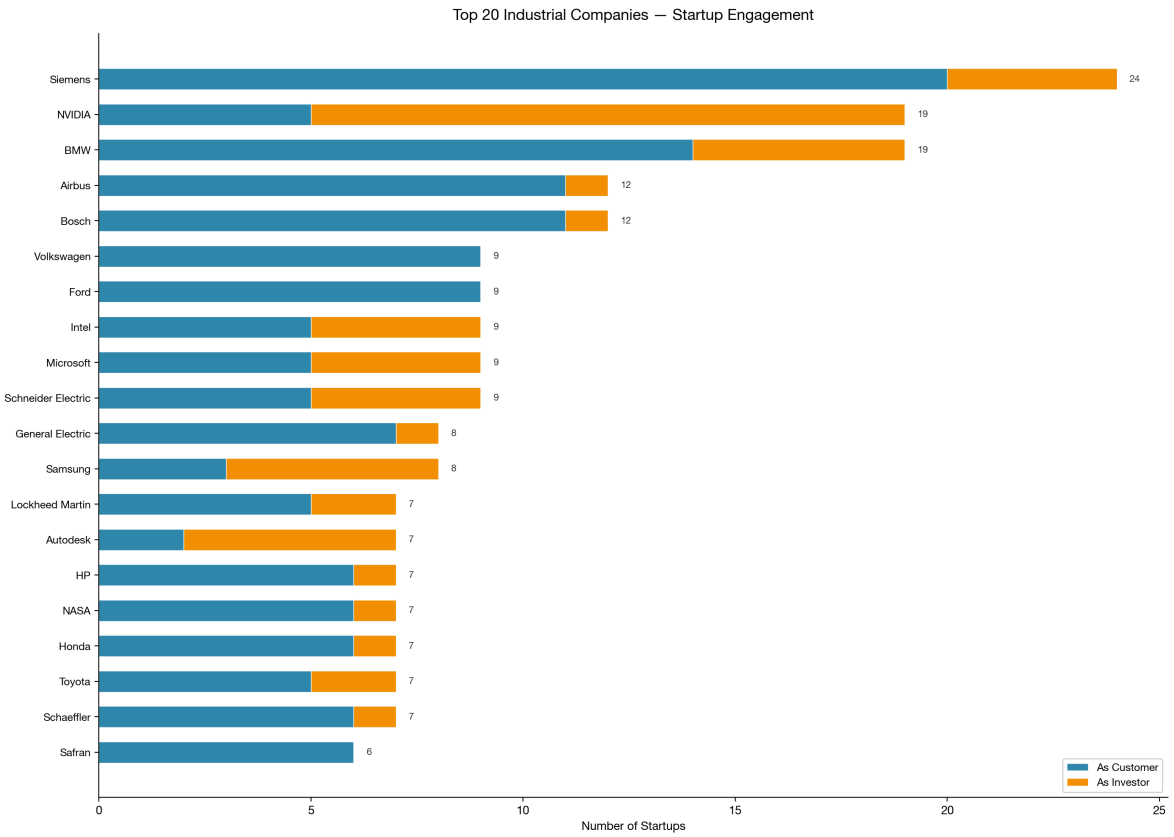


Figure 1: Figure: Top 20 Industrial Companies by Startup Engagement

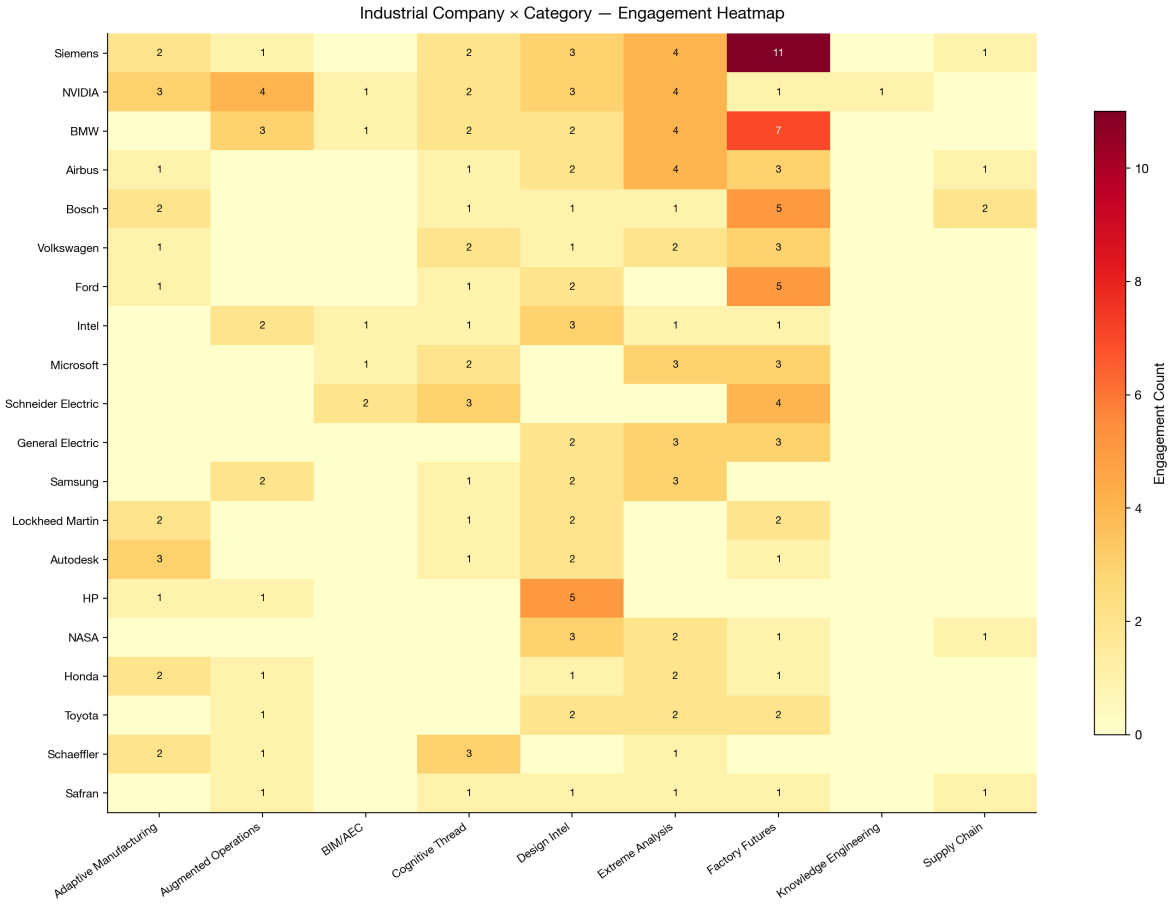


Figure 2: Figure: Category Heatmap — Industrial Engagement by Sector

with selective investments, spread across 6 categories. The top category is Factory Futures (MES, accounting for 37% of engagements. BMW holds dual roles (customer and investor) with Alitheon, Synera. BMW balances direct procurement with targeted venture bets, concentrating on factory and manufacturing technologies.

**Airbus** (12 engagements — 11 customer, 1 investor). Airbus engages primarily as a customer, spread across 6 categories. The top category is Extreme Analysis (CAE, accounting for 33% of engagements. Airbus is almost exclusively a customer, with strong concentration in simulation and analysis tools used for aerospace certification.

**Bosch** (12 engagements — 11 customer, 1 investor). Bosch engages primarily as a customer, spread across 6 categories. The top category is Factory Futures (MES, accounting for 42% of engagements. Bosch mirrors Airbus in its customer-heavy profile, with factory automation as its primary engagement category.

**Volkswagen** (9 engagements — 9 customer, 0 investor). Volkswagen engages exclusively as a customer, spread across 5 categories. The top category is Factory Futures (MES, accounting for 33% of engagements. Volkswagen has zero recorded investments — all 9 engagements are as a customer, concentrated in factory and design tools.

**Ford** (9 engagements — 9 customer, 0 investor). Ford engages exclusively as a customer, spread across 4 categories. The top category is Factory Futures (MES, accounting for 56% of engagements. Ford, like Volkswagen, is a pure customer with no venture activity. It shows the highest single-category concentration among the top 10.

**Intel** (9 engagements — 5 customer, 4 investor). Intel engages with a balanced mix of customer and investor roles, spread across 6 categories. The top category is Design Intelligence (CAD), accounting for 33% of engagements. Intel engages through both procurement and Intel Capital investments, spanning design, simulation, and manufacturing categories.

**Microsoft** (9 engagements — 5 customer, 4 investor). Microsoft engages with a balanced mix of customer and investor roles, spread across 4 categories. The top category is Extreme Analysis (CAE, accounting for 33% of engagements. Microsoft's engagements are split between direct customer relationships and M12 venture fund investments, with a concentration in simulation and analysis.

**Schneider Electric** (9 engagements — 5 customer, 4 investor). Schneider Electric engages with a balanced mix of customer and investor roles, spread across 3 categories. The top category is Factory Futures (MES, accounting for 44% of engagements. Schneider Electric holds dual roles (customer and investor) with Makersite Gmbh, Sense. Schneider Electric focuses on factory and operational technology, with SE Ventures providing the investment arm.

## Category Concentration Analysis

Industrial engagement is not evenly distributed across technology categories. The concentration reveals where large companies see the most urgent technology gaps.

### Most-Targeted Categories

| Category | Engagements | Share |
|---|---|---|
| Factory Futures (MES | 93 | 29% |
| Design Intelligence (CAD) | 55 | 17% |
| Extreme Analysis (CAE | 54 | 17% |
| Cognitive Thread (PLM | 41 | 13% |
| Augmented Operations (MOM | 30 | 9% |

Factory Futures (MES leads with 93 engagements (29% of all category-tagged interactions). This dominance reflects the universal need for manufacturing execution systems across automotive, aerospace, and heavy industry. Every company that operates a factory — from Siemens to Ford to Bosch — is actively sourcing MES and IIoT startups. Design Intelligence (CAD) ranks second at 55 engagements, driven by physics simulation requirements in aerospace and automotive. Companies like Airbus, Honda, and General Electric depend on simulation tools for design validation, structural analysis, and regulatory certification.

Extreme Analysis (CAE ranks third with 54 engagements. Design tools attract industrial attention because they sit at the start of the product development cycle — decisions made in CAD propagate through manufacturing and operations.

Rounding out the top five: Cognitive Thread (PLM (41 engagements) and Augmented Operations (MOM (30 engagements). PLM engagement comes primarily from companies managing complex product structures — Schaeffler, Anduril, and Siemens — while manufacturing-focused categories attract the broadest set of industrial buyers.

## Concentrators vs. Diversifiers

Some industrials spread their bets across many categories; others focus tightly on one or two areas. The distinction matters for competitive analysis: concentrators signal deep domain commitment, while diversifiers are hedging across multiple technology fronts or operating across multiple business units.

**Concentrators:** Schneider Electric (3 categories, 44% in Factory Futures (MES); General Electric (3 categories, 38% in Extreme Analysis (CAE); HP (3 categories, 71% in Design Intelligence (CAD)).

**Diversifiers:** Siemens (7 categories, 46% in Factory Futures (MES); NVIDIA (8 categories, 21% in Extreme Analysis (CAE); BMW (6 categories, 37% in Factory Futures (MES); Airbus (6 categories, 33% in Extreme Analysis (CAE); Bosch (6 categories, 42% in Factory Futures (MES); Intel (6 categories, 33% in Design Intelligence (CAD)).

The concentrator pattern typically signals a company that is solving a specific operational problem — Schneider Electric's factory focus, for example, or HP's design tool procurement. The diversifier pattern indicates a company exploring multiple technology fronts simultaneously, as Siemens and NVIDIA do across their broad product portfolios.

The category data also reveals a gap: supply chain management and BIM/AEC categories attract far less industrial attention than factory and simulation tools. This may reflect the relative maturity of incumbent solutions in those areas, or it may indicate that startups in those categories have not yet achieved the kind of reference customer base that triggers

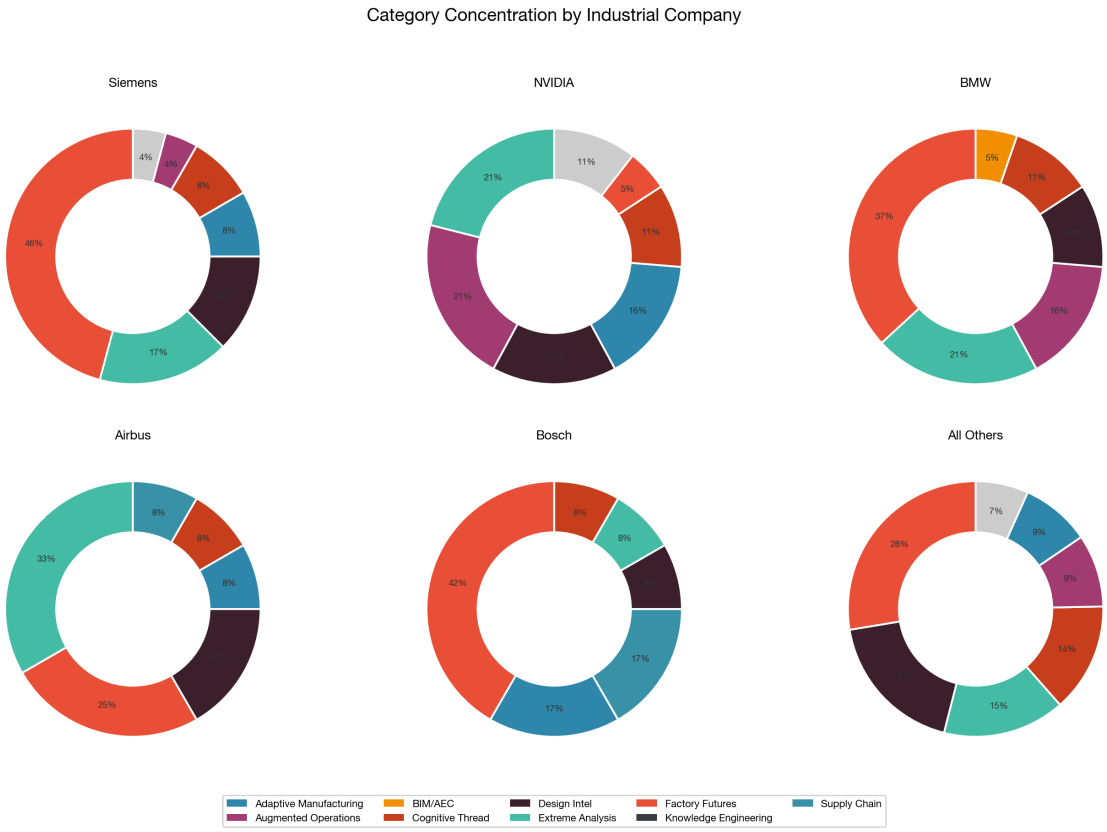


Figure 3: Figure: Category Concentration by Industrial Company

industrial procurement cycles.

## Competitive Intelligence Matrix

When two industrial companies engage with the same startups, it signals convergent technology strategies. The overlap matrix below reveals which industrials are making similar bets — and which are pursuing differentiated approaches.

Overlap analysis examines the union of each company's customer and investor startup sets. A shared startup means both industrials have independently identified that company as worth engaging with, either through procurement or investment. Higher overlap counts suggest closer strategic alignment between the two industrials. Pairs with zero overlap are pursuing entirely independent technology sourcing.

### Highest-Overlap Pairs

| Company A | Company B | Shared Startups | Examples |
|---|---|---|---|
| NVIDIA | Microsoft | 4 | PhysicsX, Rescale, ShipReality |
| Volkswagen | Ford | 4 | Acerta, Gravity Sketch, SPREAD |
| Siemens | BMW | 3 | Cybus, DataProphet, Dive CAE |
| NVIDIA | Samsung | 3 | Cusp AI, LandingAI, Rescale |
| BMW | Airbus | 3 | SPREAD, Synera, TETMET |
| BMW | Volkswagen | 3 | Acerta, SPREAD, Synera |
| BMW | Ford | 3 | Acerta, HiveMQ, SPREAD |
| Airbus | Volkswagen | 3 | SPREAD, Synera, trinckle 3D Gmbh |

### Technology Clusters

**Automotive cluster:** BMW, Volkswagen, Ford share overlapping startup relationships, particularly in factory automation and generative design. BMW, Volkswagen, and Ford each share 3-4 startups, reflecting convergent investment in next-generation manufacturing and design tools.

**Aerospace and defense cluster:** Airbus, General Electric, Lockheed Martin converge on simulation and analysis startups. Airbus and General Electric share 3 startups, reflecting the shared demand for physics-based tools in certification-heavy industries.

**Technology platform cluster:** NVIDIA, Intel, Microsoft, Samsung share overlap driven by their venture investment arms. NVIDIA and Microsoft share 4 startups — the highest pairwise overlap in the dataset — reflecting their competing strategies to become the compute platform for engineering simulation.

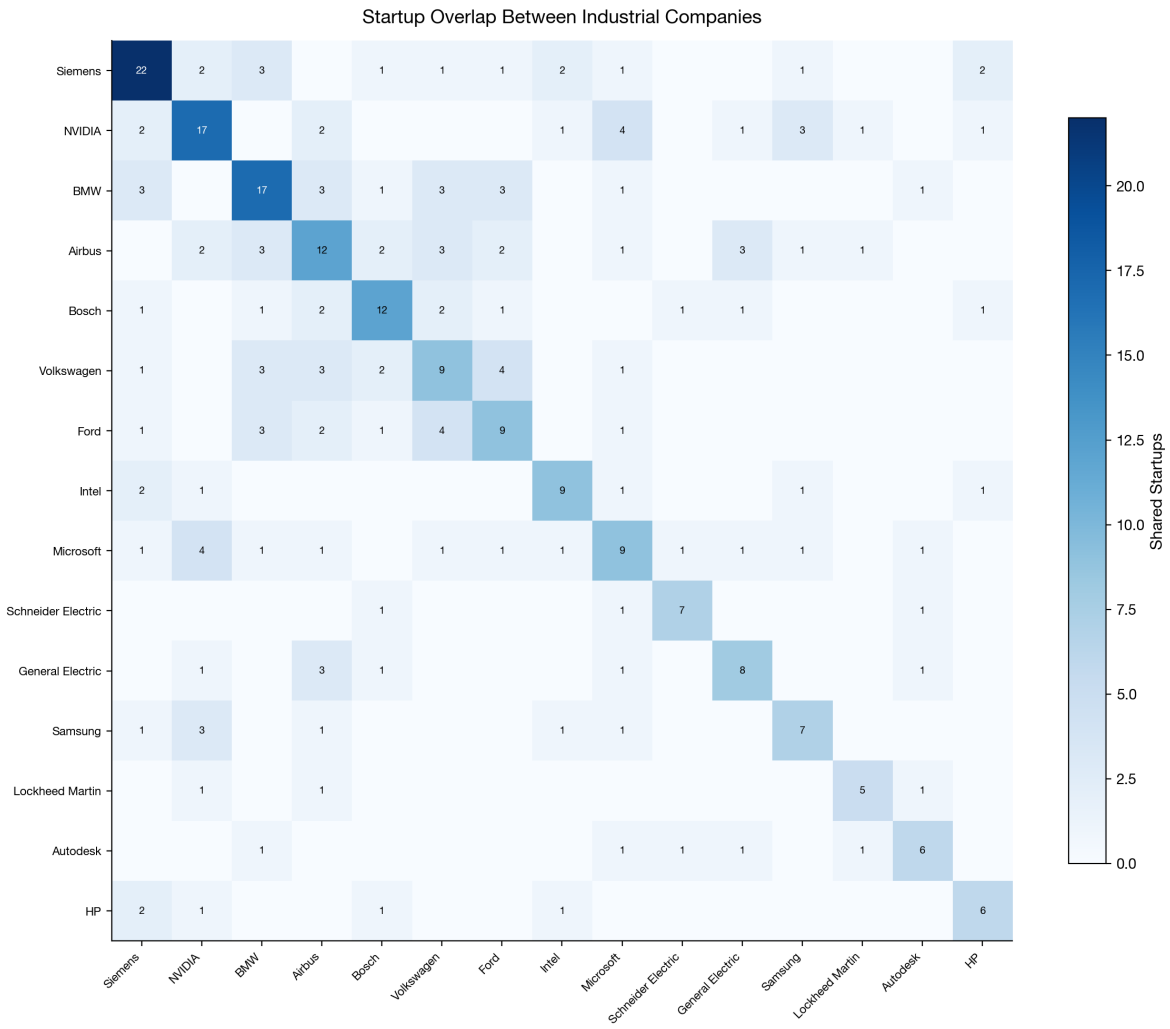


Figure 4: Figure: Startup Overlap Between Top Industrials

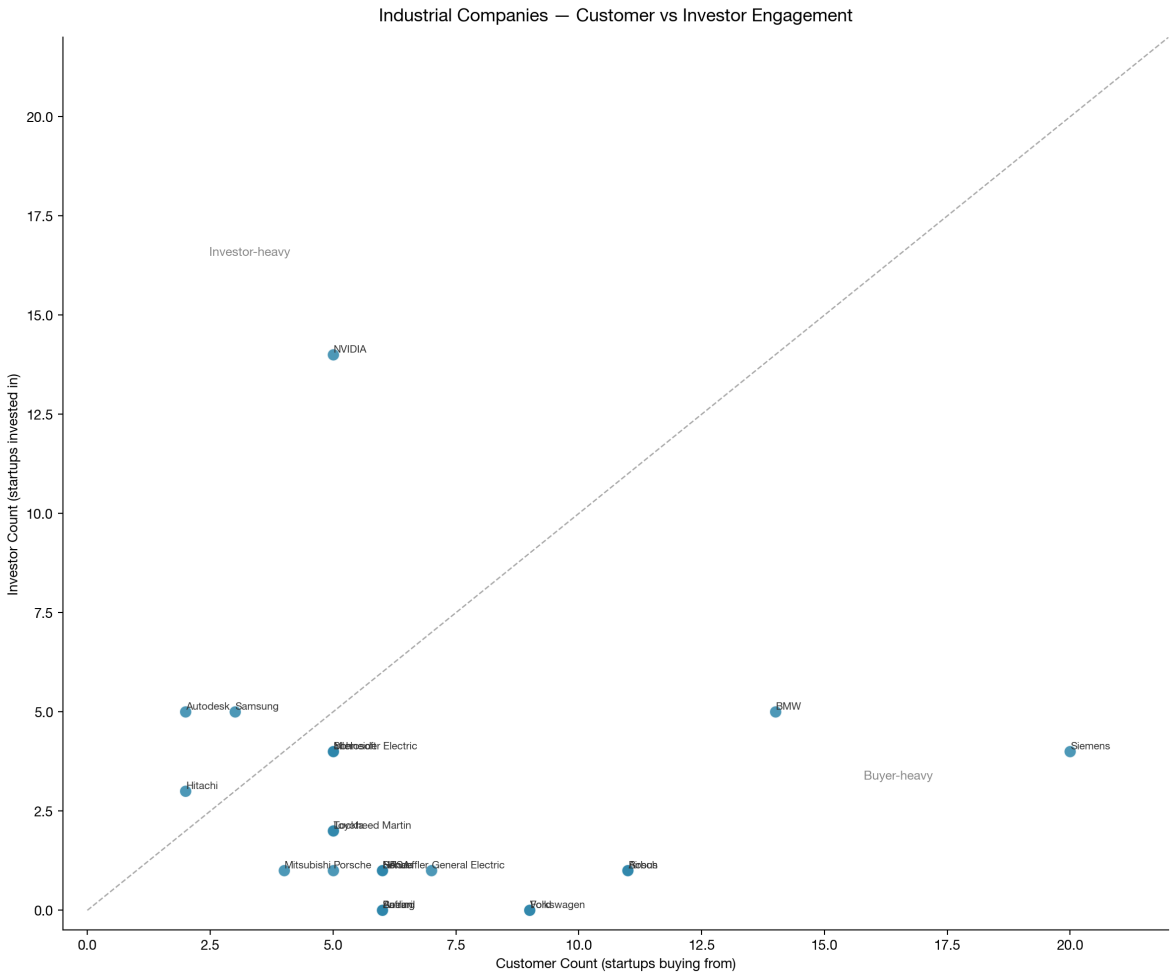


Figure 5: Figure: Customer vs. Investor Engagement Profile

### Reading the Matrix

Companies with zero or minimal overlap are pursuing distinct technology strategies. Schneider Electric and Lockheed Martin, for instance, engage with different startup populations because their operational requirements diverge — factory energy management vs. defense engineering. High overlap between companies in different industries (e.g., NVIDIA and Microsoft) signals platform competition rather than end-market convergence. Low overlap between direct competitors (e.g., Airbus and Boeing) may indicate differentiated sourcing strategies or deliberate avoidance of shared vendors.

## Implications for Technology Buyers

The engagement data carries concrete signals for procurement and technology strategy teams.

### Dual-Role Lock-In Signals

When a large industrial is both a customer and an investor in a startup, the relationship goes beyond a standard vendor contract. The investing company has financial incentive to maintain and expand the relationship, which can mean preferential access to product roadmap input, early feature releases, and co-development agreements. It can also mean reduced negotiating flexibility if you are competing for the same startup's attention as a prospective buyer.

10 of the top 20 industrials hold at least one dual role. Key examples:

- **Siemens** is both customer and investor in PhysicsX, rhobot.ai
- **NVIDIA** is both customer and investor in Phaidra, PhysicsX
- **BMW** is both customer and investor in Alitheon, Synera
- **Schneider Electric** is both customer and investor in Makersite Gmbh, Sense
- **Samsung** is both customer and investor in Rescale
- **Lockheed Martin** is both customer and investor in CloudNC, nTop

If your organization is evaluating any of these startups, the dual-role relationship is worth factoring into vendor risk assessment. A startup's largest customer-investor may receive priority roadmap influence.

### Category Signals for Procurement

Categories with high industrial engagement — especially Factory Futures (MES — indicate mature buyer demand. Startups in these categories face real procurement cycles, have reference customers, and are building for enterprise requirements. This is generally positive for buyers: competition among startups for industrial customers drives better pricing and faster feature development.

Categories with sparse industrial engagement — such as Streamlined Supply Chain (SCM), Bleeding Edge BIM (AEC/BIM), Knowledge Engineering (R&D — may indicate earlier-stage markets where startups have fewer enterprise reference customers. Buyers entering these categories should expect less mature sales processes and more technology risk.

## Competitive Positioning Reads

The 251 customer relationships and 74 investment relationships in the dataset are a proxy for where major industrials see technology gaps in their operations. When Siemens — itself a major software vendor — buys from 20 startups, it signals areas where the incumbent software stack is insufficient.

For technology buyers inside industrial organizations, the key question is whether your competitors are already using the startup you are evaluating. The overlap matrix in Section 5 provides a direct read: if your competitor and three peers are already customers, the startup has validated product-market fit in your segment. Conversely, if no peer industrials appear in a startup's customer list, you are taking on additional adoption risk.

The data also reveals a structural asymmetry: industrials are 3-4x more likely to buy from engineering startups than to invest in them. For startups, this means revenue traction with industrials is far more achievable than investment. For buyers, it means the startups winning industrial customers are doing so on product merit, not on the strength of a strategic investor's mandate.

## What to Watch

Three dynamics are worth tracking in future quarters. First, whether NVIDIA's investment-heavy engagement model produces customer conversions — its portfolio startups may become NVIDIA customers as their GPU compute needs grow. Second, whether the automotive cluster's shared startup relationships lead to consolidation pressure, as startups struggle to serve competing OEMs simultaneously. Third, whether Siemens' position as the most active industrial creates a gravitational effect, pulling startups into its partner orbit and making it harder for competitors to access the same technology.